

The Mauryas, the Post-Mauryan Kingdoms and the Guptas - The Foundation Track

Chapter F5.4 — From Zero: India's First Empire, Ashoka's Edicts, the Deccan and the Sangam South, the Kushanas, and the Gupta Classical Age

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NOTE · HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

This is the chapter that fills the RULERS slot of the F5.1 template for the whole of ancient India, and it is therefore where chronological-order questions come from. It covers India's first empire under the Mauryas, with the Arthashastra and Megasthenes as its sources and Ashoka's inscriptions as the only body of contemporary royal writing the period produced. Ashoka gets a session to himself, because his edicts are the evidence, his dhamma is regularly misdescribed as Buddhism, and his lion capital is on the Indian State Emblem. The chapter then takes the five centuries of political fragmentation that follow - Sungas, Satavahanas, Indo-Greeks, Shakas and Kushanas in the north and Deccan, the Sangam kingdoms of the Tamil south, and the Indo-Roman trade that connected them - and closes on the Guptas, their decentralised administration, and an honest assessment of the Golden Age claim. Study time 4 hours.

This is the FOUNDATION layer. Regnal dates for the Mauryas, Kushanas and Guptas are the conventional ones and are approximate; Kanishka's accession in 78 CE and its identification with the start of the Saka era is the standard position but is not universally accepted. Attributions of individual literary works to individual reigns follow tradition where inscriptional confirmation is absent. Figures for Mauryan army strength are Megasthenes' as reported by later writers and should be treated as reported, not verified.

Table of Contents

0. Why This Chapter Is the Spine of Ancient India	3
1. Session 1 - The Mauryan Empire ★★★★★	4
1.1 Mauryan administration - the most elaborate in ancient India	5
2. Session 2 - Ashoka ★★★★★	6
2.1 The edicts - the classification, and the ones that are asked	7
3. Session 3 - Five Centuries of Fragmentation ★★★★★☆	9
3.1 The Gangetic remnant and the Deccan	10
3.2 The north-west - four waves, in order	10
3.3 The Sangam south, and the trade that enriched everyone	12
4. Session 4 - The Guptas and Harsha ★★★★★	13
4.1 The classical achievement, and an honest verdict	15
5. Graded Practice - 42 Questions ★★★★★	17
5.1 Level 1 - Recognition	17
5.2 Level 2 - Understanding	18
5.3 Level 3 - Recruitment Test standard	19
6. Answers and Explanations	21
6.1 Level 1 - answers	21
6.2 Level 2 - answers	22
6.3 Level 3 - answers	23
7. One-Minute Revision	24
8. Five-Minute Wall Sheet	27

0. Why This Chapter Is the Spine of Ancient India

Everything before this chapter was a society. This is where the dynasties, dates and empires live.

WHY THIS EXISTS · WHAT THIS CHAPTER IS FOR, AND HOW TO READ IT

F5.1 gave you a five-slot template: **sites, rulers, texts, monuments, distinctive feature**. F5.1 filled the **sites** slot for prehistory and the Harappans. F5.2 and F5.3 filled the **texts** slot for the Vedas and the two heterodox canons. **This chapter fills the RULERS slot for the entire ancient period, and it is the only chapter that does.**

That has a direct consequence for how you use it. Chronological-order questions - the format F5.1 told you to anchor on four fixed points - are answered almost entirely from this chapter. **So the dynastic sequence matters more here than any individual fact**, and the chapter is built to give you sequence first and detail second.

Read it against three questions and no others:

- 1 **Who came after whom?** The order of dynasties, and the two or three rulers per dynasty who are actually asked
- 2 **What is each ruler famous for one thing?** A conquest, an inscription, a monument, a visitor, a title
- 3 **What is the evidence?** This is the first period with **contemporary royal inscriptions**, and questions about sources concentrate here

One warning about scale. This chapter covers roughly **nine hundred years and a dozen dynasties**. It would be easy to drown in it. **The stopping rule from F5.1 is doing real work here: for most dynasties you need the founder, the greatest ruler, the capital and one distinguishing achievement. That is four facts, not forty.** The tables mark what to hold.

PYQ CONNECTION · WHERE THIS CHAPTER'S MARKS ACTUALLY SIT

- 1 **HIGHEST yield - Ashoka.** His edicts, his dhamma, Kalinga, and the **Sarnath lion capital as the State Emblem** - which crosses into Polity and General Knowledge too, so it pays three times
- 2 **HIGH yield - the inscription-to-ruler pairings.** Allahabad Prashasti to Samudragupta, Junagadh to Rudradaman I, Hathigumpha to Kharavela, Aihole to Pulakeshin II, Nasik to Gautamiputra Satakarni - a standard matching set, and cheap
- 3 **HIGH yield - the Gupta cultural names.** Kalidasa, Aryabhata, Varahamihira, Nalanda, the Mehrauli iron pillar
- 4 **MODERATE - dynastic founders, capitals, the coinage firsts, and the Sangam three with Tirukkural**

And note the trap the chapter is built around. The post-Mauryan centuries have **many dynasties running at once in different regions**, and candidates try to learn them as one sequence. **They are not a sequence - they are a map**, which is why Session 3 is organised by region.

STUDY SESSION · CHAPTER F5.4 - THE FOUR SESSIONS

- 1 **Session 1 - The Mauryan empire:** sources, Chandragupta, Bindusara, and the most elaborate administration ancient India produced (Section 1)
- 2 **Session 2 - Ashoka:** Kalinga, dhamma, the edicts as a body of evidence, the pillars, and why the empire fell (Section 2)
- 3 **Session 3 - Five centuries of fragmentation:** Sungas and Satavahanas, the four waves of foreign rule, the Sangam south, and Indo-Roman trade (Section 3)
- 4 **Session 4 - The Guptas and Harsha:** the dynasty, its decentralised state, the classical achievement, and an honest verdict on the Golden Age (Section 4)

Then **42 graded questions**.

1. Session 1 - The Mauryan Empire ★★★★★

The first state to hold most of the subcontinent, and the first whose administration we can describe in detail rather than infer.

START FROM ZERO · WHY THE MAURYAS ARE A DIFFERENT KIND OF SUBJECT

Everything up to this point has been reconstructed indirectly - objects for the Harappans, hymns for the Vedic period, canonical texts for the reform movements. **The Mauryas are the first Indian dynasty we can study from documents that were written to record government.** Three bodies of evidence, and the paper asks about all three:

- 1 **Ashoka's inscriptions - contemporary, official, and issued by the ruler himself.**
Unreadable until **Prinsep deciphered Brahmi in 1837**, which is why the whole dynasty was recovered only in the nineteenth century
- 2 **The Arthashastra of Kautilya** - a treatise on statecraft, administration, taxation, law and espionage. **A manual of how a state SHOULD work, which is not the same as a record of how this one did**, and that distinction is worth stating
- 3 **Megasthenes' Indica** - the Seleucid ambassador's account of Chandragupta's court and capital. **Survives only in fragments quoted by later Greek writers**, so it is second-hand, and some of it is plainly wrong

The historian's caution to carry, because a "not correct" question can be built on it. These three sources are of different kinds - **prescriptive, official and foreign** - and they do not always agree. **The Arthashastra describes an ideal, Ashoka's edicts describe what a king wished proclaimed, and Megasthenes describes what a foreigner understood.** None is a neutral record, and where a question offers a confident administrative detail, the safe answer is usually the one the inscriptions support.

MUST MASTER · CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA AND BINDUSARA

CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA (c. 321-297 BCE) - founder of the dynasty and of India's first empire.

- 1 **Overthrew Dhana Nanda**, the last Nanda, with the help of **Kautilya (Chanakya)**, and took **Magadha** with its iron, rice and river position already in place - **Session 4 of F5.2 explains why that base was worth capturing**
- 2 **Defeated Seleucus Nicator** - Alexander's general and successor in the east - in about **305 BCE**. By the resulting treaty Chandragupta gained **Arachosia, Gedrosia and the Paropamisadae** (roughly eastern Afghanistan and Baluchistan) and **gave 500 war elephants**
- 3 **Megasthenes came as Seleucus's ambassador** to his court as part of that settlement
- 4 **Became a Jain** in later life, abdicated, and by tradition **died by Sallekhana at Shravanabelagola** - the Jain practice from F5.3, and the reason that site matters twice
- 5 Capital **Pataliputra**

The Seleucus episode is the single most examinable fact here, and note its direction: an Indian ruler defeated a Macedonian successor state and gained territory. That is the answer to any question implying Greek dominance persisted after Alexander.

BINDUSARA (c. 297-273 BCE) - the least examined of the three, and three facts cover him.

- 1 Called **Amitraghata**, "slayer of foes", which the Greeks rendered **Amitrochates**
- 2 Held **Ajivika** sympathies - the determinist sect from F5.3
- 3 Received **Deimachus** as ambassador from **Antiochus I**

He is asked almost exclusively as the link between Chandragupta and Ashoka, so knowing his position in the sequence matters more than his reign.

1.1 Mauryan administration - the most elaborate in ancient India

This is the substance of Session 1. Learn it as five layers, because that is how questions are framed.

Layer	What to know
The centre	Capital at Pataliputra . The king at the head, advised by a council, the Mantriparishad . Senior officials were Mahamatyas and Amatyas . The Arthashastra describes some 27 superintendents (adhyakshas) over departments from mines to weaving
Provinces	Conventionally four provinces plus the centre , each under a viceroy of royal blood titled Kumara or Aryaputra . Taxila for the north-west, Ujjain for the west, Suvarnagiri for the south, Tosali for the east, with Pataliputra holding the centre. The four provincial capitals are a standard question
Districts and villages	District officers were the Pradeshika (overall charge), Rajuka (survey, assessment and, under Ashoka, judicial powers) and Yukta (accounts). The village headman was the Gramika , and the Gopa and Sthanika worked between village and district
Revenue and finance	The Samaharta was chief collector of revenue and the Sannidhata the treasurer. Land revenue was the main head, conventionally one-sixth of produce, with bali and bhaga continuing from F5.2. Sita was crown land cultivated directly by the state - a large state farming sector, which is unusual and examinable
City and army	City administration under the Nagaraka . Megasthenes describes SIX committees of FIVE members each for municipal functions, and another six for the war office - covering infantry, cavalry, elephants, chariots, navy and transport. He reports an army of 600,000 infantry, 30,000 cavalry and 9,000 elephants , figures which are reported rather than verified

The five layers of the Mauryan state

KNOW · ESPIONAGE, AND THE TWO FEATURES THAT MAKE THIS STATE UNUSUAL

The spy system. The Arthashastra treats intelligence as a department of government, not an expedient. Spies are **gudhapurushas**, and they are of two kinds: **sanstha**, stationed in one place, and **sanchara**, wandering. **They reported on officials as much as on enemies** - the state watched its own administration.

Two features worth naming as unusual for the ancient world, because "which is characteristic of Mauryan administration" is a real question:

- 1 **A large state economic sector.** Beyond taxation the state ran **mines, forests, ferries, salt, liquor, mints and the sita crown lands directly**. This is not a state that merely taxed private activity; it was itself the largest economic actor
- 2 **Written, centralised and inspected.** Accounts, surveys and reporting officers, with spies auditing the auditors

Hold both features, because Session 2 uses them: the Mauryan state's reach depended on a documented, inspected, salaried officialdom, and that is precisely what made it fragile.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 1

- 1 Name the three bodies of Mauryan evidence and the limitation of each
- 2 Why does the Arthashastra describe something different from what the edicts do?
- 3 Whom did Chandragupta overthrow, with whose help, and what base did he inherit?
- 4 Give the year, opponent, territorial result and elephant payment of the Seleucus settlement
- 5 How did Chandragupta end his life, and where?
- 6 Give Bindusara's title, his religious leaning, and his ambassador
- 7 Name the four provincial capitals and the title of a viceroy
- 8 Distinguish Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta; and Samaharta from Sannidhata
- 9 What was sita land, and why does it matter?
- 10 Give Megasthenes' committee structure and his army figures, with the correct caveat
- 11 Name the two kinds of spy, and say whom they watched

2. Session 2 - Ashoka ★★★★★

The only ancient Indian ruler who left us his own words, and the one whose religious policy is most often described wrongly.

MUST MASTER · ASHOKA - THE REIGN, AND THE WAR THAT CHANGED IT

ASHOKA (c. 268-232 BCE), grandson of Chandragupta. Accession about **273 BCE**, formal coronation about **269 BCE**.

- 1 **Titles in his own inscriptions: Devanampiya** ("beloved of the gods") and **Piyadasi** ("of pleasing appearance"). **His personal name Ashoka appears in only a few - the MASKI and GUJARRA minor rock edicts are the ones to name**, and it was those that finally identified Devanampiya Piyadasi as Ashoka
- 2 **The Kalinga war, c. 261 BCE**, in his **eighth regnal year**. **Recorded in his own Major Rock Edict XIII**, which states the numbers killed and deported and expresses remorse. **This is the only ancient Indian record of a king declaring regret for his own victory**
- 3 **After Kalinga he abandoned war as an instrument of policy** and adopted **dhamma vijaya** - conquest by righteousness - in place of military conquest
- 4 **Convened the Third Buddhist Council at Pataliputra, c. 250 BCE**, under Moggaliputta Tissa, and **sent missionaries abroad including his son Mahendra and daughter Sanghamitra to Sri Lanka** - the F5.3 facts, from the political side
- 5 Died about **232 BCE**

Why Kalinga is the hinge. The empire was already nearly complete; Kalinga was the last major independent territory on the eastern coast. **Its conquest completed the empire and simultaneously ended the policy that built it.** That is a genuine historical irony and a good thing to be able to state in one sentence.

COMMON UPSC TRAP · ASHOKA'S DHAMMA IS NOT BUDDHISM - AND THIS IS THE CHAPTER'S MOST IMPORTANT DISTINCTION

Ashoka was personally a Buddhist. He visited Buddhist sites, convened the Third Council, sent missionaries, and said so. **But the dhamma he proclaimed in his edicts to his subjects is not Buddhist doctrine.** Read the edicts and what you find is a **civic and moral code**, not a religion:

- 1 **Respect for elders, parents, teachers and brahmanas**
- 2 **Ahimsa** - restraint in killing animals, restriction of royal hunts and of animal slaughter in the kitchen
- 3 **Truthfulness, compassion, liberality, and kindness to servants and slaves**
- 4 **Toleration of all sects. Major Rock Edict XII is the edict of religious tolerance**, and it goes further than tolerance - it says that honouring one's own sect while disparaging another **damages one's own sect**
- 5 **Practical welfare** - roads, wells, rest houses, medical care for men and animals

What is conspicuously ABSENT from the dhamma of the edicts: the **Four Noble Truths**, the **Eightfold Path**, **nirvana**, **anatta**, the **sangha** as an object of lay obligation - in short, **every distinctively Buddhist doctrine from F5.3.**

So the correct formulation, and it is the answer to a whole family of questions: Ashoka's dhamma was a common ethical code addressed to a religiously plural empire, not the propagation of Buddhism. Any option saying he "made Buddhism the state religion" or "imposed Buddhist doctrine on his subjects" is **wrong**, and it is offered constantly.

Enforcement. He created **Dhamma Mahamatras** in his **thirteenth regnal year** - officers specifically charged with promoting dhamma and looking after the welfare of sects and vulnerable groups. **A new cadre of officials created for a moral purpose is itself an examinable innovation**, and it is a fair thing to admire: the machinery was built to match the policy.

2.1 The edicts - the classification, and the ones that are asked

Ashoka's inscriptions are the largest body of contemporary evidence from ancient India, and they are classified by surface and length. Learn the classification, then the individual edicts that carry questions.

Class	How many	What to know
Major Rock Edicts	14	On rock surfaces across the empire. XIII is the KALINGA edict with the remorse and the doctrine of dhamma vijaya - the single most important edict . XII is the edict of RELIGIOUS TOLERANCE
Minor Rock Edicts	Several	MASKI and GUJJARRA name Ashoka personally , which is how the identification was made. Also Nettur and Udegolam
Major Pillar Edicts	7	On monolithic polished sandstone pillars, mostly in the Ganga plain - Delhi-Topra, Delhi-Meerut, Lauriya-Araraj, Lauriya-Nandangarh, Rampurva, Allahabad
Minor Pillar Edicts	Several	RUMMINDEI (Lumbini) records his visit to the Buddha's birthplace and a TAX CONCESSION - bali remitted and bhaga reduced to one-eighth . The SCHISM edict (Sarnath, Sanchi, Allahabad-Kosambi) warns against splitting the sangha. The Queen's Edict records his queen Karuvaki's donations
Bilingual and foreign-script	-	The KANDAHAR edict in GREEK and ARAMAIC , in present-day Afghanistan - the F5.1 fact, and evidence that the edicts were issued in languages the local population read

Ashoka's inscriptions - classification and the examinable individual edicts

Two structural points worth as much as the contents. The language is **Prakrit** in Brahmi script, with **Kharosthi** in the north-west - **the ruler addressed his subjects in the vernacular, exactly as the reform movements of F5.3 did**. And **they run from Afghanistan to Karnataka, so their distribution is itself the map of the empire**.

KNOW · THE PILLARS, THE CAPITAL, AND THE STATE EMBLEM

The pillars are the finest surviving Mauryan art, and the paper asks about them as objects as well as inscriptions.

- 1 Material: sandstone quarried at CHUNAR**, near Varanasi, and transported hundreds of miles
- 2 Monolithic** - each shaft cut from a single stone - and carrying a **very high polish** that later periods did not reproduce
- 3 Animal capitals: the lion** at Sarnath, the **bull** at Rampurva, the **elephant** at Sankisa, the **lion** at Lauriya-Nandangarh

The Sarnath Lion Capital, and this is the highest-value single fact in the chapter. Four lions back to back, on an abacus carrying **four animals - lion, elephant, bull and horse - separated by four wheels**, above an inverted lotus.

- 1 Adopted as the STATE EMBLEM OF INDIA on 26 January 1950**
- 2 In the Emblem only THREE lions are visible**, the fourth being hidden behind
- 3 The motto "Satyameva Jayate" beneath it comes from the Mundaka Upanishad** - the F5.2 fact
- 4 The wheel of the abacus, the Dharmachakra, is the wheel on the national flag**
- 5 The bell-shaped inverted lotus of the original is NOT part of the State Emblem**

That last point is a real question. The Emblem is an adaptation, not a copy: **it omits the lotus base and shows three lions**. Options asserting a faithful reproduction are wrong.

WHY THIS EXISTS · WHY THE MAURYAN EMPIRE FELL - FOUR EXPLANATIONS, AND HOW TO ANSWER

Ashoka died about 232 BCE; the last Maurya, **Brihadratha**, was killed by his own commander **Pushyamitra Sunga** in about **185 BCE**. **Fifty years from the death of the greatest emperor to the end of the dynasty**, and the standard question asks why.

- 1 **Brahmanical reaction - Haraprasad Sastri's** argument, that Ashoka's ban on animal sacrifice and his elevation of dhamma antagonised the priestly class. **Weak, because the edicts are explicitly respectful of brahmanas**
- 2 **Financial strain - D. D. Kosambi's** argument, resting on evidence of debased punch-marked coinage: the empire's welfare spending and vast officialdom outran its revenue
- 3 **Ashoka's pacifism** - the popular argument, that abandoning war left the empire defenceless. **Weak, because the empire survived fifty years after him and there is no evidence the army was disbanded**
- 4 **Over-centralisation and weak successors - Romila Thapar's** argument, and the strongest. **The state depended on a salaried, inspected bureaucracy personally loyal to the king. Such a system cannot survive mediocre kings, because there is no other source of cohesion** - no shared religion of state, no feudal aristocracy with its own stake, no regional institutions

The answer to give: a combination, with over-centralisation dominant. And note the connection back to Session 1 - **the very features that made the Mauryan state impressive, central inspection and salaried officers and a directly run economy, are the features that made it unable to survive a weak centre.** It is the same institutional argument F5.3 used about Buddhism's monasteries: **capability concentrated at the centre disappears when the centre does.**

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 2

- 1 Give Ashoka's two inscriptional titles, and name the two edicts that record his personal name
- 2 Date the Kalinga war, give its regnal year, and name the edict that records it
- 3 What is dhamma vijaya?
- 4 List five contents of Ashoka's dhamma, and five distinctively Buddhist doctrines absent from it
- 5 State in one sentence why the dhamma was not Buddhism
- 6 Which edict is the edict of religious tolerance, and what does it actually argue?
- 7 What are Dhamma Mahamatras and when were they created?
- 8 Give the four classes of inscription with their numbers
- 9 What does the Rummindei pillar record, including the tax concession?
- 10 Where was the pillar stone quarried, and name three animal capitals with their sites
- 11 Give three ways the State Emblem differs from the Sarnath capital
- 12 Name the four explanations of Mauryan decline with their proponents, and say which is strongest

3. Session 3 - Five Centuries of Fragmentation



Not a sequence but a map. Learn this session by region, or it will not stay.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH · HOW TO HOLD FIVE HUNDRED YEARS OF SEVERAL DYNASTIES AT ONCE

From **185 BCE to about 320 CE** there is no single power over northern India. **Several dynasties rule simultaneously in different regions**, and the commonest study error is to try to memorise them as one chronological list. **They are not a list. They are a map with a time axis.**

Divide the period into three theatres and hold each separately:

- 1 **The north-west** - successive waves of foreign rule entering through the passes:
Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, Kushanas. Learn these as a **sequence**, because they genuinely follow one another
- 2 **The Deccan** - the **Satavahanas**, essentially one long indigenous dynasty
- 3 **The Tamil south** - the **Sangam** kingdoms, three of them, coexisting and quarrelling

Plus the Gangetic remnant of the Mauryan core, where the **Sungas** and then the **Kanvas** hold Magadha.

And one economic development running across all three theatres: the **Indo-Roman trade**, which is what makes this era prosperous despite being politically fragmented. **That last point is the analytical observation worth carrying - political unity and economic prosperity are not the same thing, and this period proves it.**

3.1 The Gangetic remnant and the Deccan

Dynasty	Founder and capital	What to know
Sunga	Pushyamitra Sunga , 185 BCE ; Pataliputra, with Vidisha important	Killed the last Maurya Brihadratha . Revived Vedic ritual and performed ashvamedha . Patanjali , author of the Mahabhashya, belongs to this period. The Bharhut stupa and the Sanchi railings and gateways are Sunga-period work - so the dynasty matters for F5.5. The Heliodorus pillar at Besnagar , set up by an Indo-Greek envoy to a Sunga king, records a Greek turned Vaishnava. Kalidasa's Malavikagnimitra is about the Sunga prince Agnimitra . Last ruler Devabhuti
Kanva	Vasudeva	Killed Devabhuti and held Magadha briefly. Asked only as the dynasty between the Sungas and the Satavahana expansion - one fact is enough
Satavahana	Simuka ; capital Pratishthana (Paithan)	The Deccan power, from roughly the first century BCE to the third century CE. Gautamiputra Satakarni is the greatest - he defeated the Shaka ruler Nahapana and is called destroyer of Shakas, Pahlavas and Yavanas in the Nasik prashasti , an inscription issued by his mother Gautami Balashri . Matronymic names are a distinctive Satavahana feature - rulers named after their mothers. Official language Prakrit . Coins largely of lead and potin . The first dynasty to make systematic land grants to brahmanas and Buddhist monks , which is the beginning of a practice that shapes all later Indian administration. Patronised Karle, Nasik and Amaravati

Sungas, Kanvas and Satavahanas

Two points from this table that are worth more than they look. First, **matronymics** - Gautamiputra means "son of Gautami" - are unusual enough in Indian dynastic practice to be a reliable identification question. Second, **the Satavahana land grants** are the seed of the **agrahara** system and of the decentralised, grant-based state that Session 4 will show the Guptas building. **The Mauryan state paid salaries; the Gupta state gave land. The Satavahanas are where the change begins.**

3.2 The north-west - four waves, in order

Wave	Key rulers	What to know
Indo-Greeks (Bactrian Greeks)	Demetrius, Menander	Menander (Milinda) is the one asked - converted to Buddhism by Nagasena , and the dialogue is the Milindapanha of F5.3. The Indo-Greeks issued the first coins in India carrying a portrait and the king's name , which is the F5.1 numismatics fact and the reason their chronology is secure. They also seed the Gandhara school of sculpture
Shakas (Scythians)	Nahapana, Rudradaman I	The Western Kshatrapas, based in Gujarat and Malwa. Rudradaman I is the one asked , for the Junagadh / Girnar rock inscription - the first long inscription in SANSKRIT , and it records his repair of the Sudarshana lake originally built under the Mauryas. The SAKA ERA begins in 78 CE and is the era used in the Indian national calendar
Parthians (Pahlavas)	Gondophernes	Brief rule in the north-west. Associated with the tradition of St Thomas's mission to India - the one fact that carries a question
Kushanas	Kujula Kadphises, Vima Kadphises, KANISHKA , Huvishka, Vasudeva	The most important of the four. Kanishka's accession in 78 CE is conventionally identified with the start of the Saka era . Capital Purushapura (Peshawar) , with Mathura as a second centre. Convened the Fourth Buddhist Council in Kashmir (F5.3). Patronised Ashvaghosha, Vasumitra, Nagarjuna and the physician Charaka . The Kushanas issued the purest gold coins of ancient India, and Kanishka's coins carry the FIRST IMAGES OF THE BUDDHA on coinage . Both the Gandhara and Mathura schools of sculpture flourish under them

The four waves of foreign rule in the north-west

HIGH YIELD · THE THREE SCULPTURE SCHOOLS - MATERIAL ANSWERS THE QUESTION

All three flourish in this period, all three are confused by candidates, and **the distinction resolves on MATERIAL, which is why material is the thing to learn**.

- 1 GANDHARA** - north-west, under the Kushanas. **Grey schist**, and strong **Greco-Roman** influence: wavy hair, heavy realistic drapery, often a moustache. **Also called the Greco-Buddhist school**
- 2 MATHURA** - Uttar Pradesh. **Spotted red sandstone from Sikri**, and an **indigenous** tradition: fuller figures, thin clinging drapery, shaven head, decorated halo. Produced **Jain and Brahmanical images as well as Buddhist**
- 3 AMARAVATI** - Andhra, under the **Satavahanas and Ikshvakus**. **White limestone**, and crowded **narrative** panels of slender animated figures

F5.5 takes all three in detail. This box exists so that the schools are already attached to their dynasties before you get there.

3.3 The Sangam south, and the trade that enriched everyone

Kingdom	Capital and port	What to know
Chera	Capital Vanji (Karur) ; port Muziris	The Kerala coast. Muziris is the great pepper port of the Indo-Roman trade and is named in Roman sources
Chola	Capital Uraiyur ; port Puhar (Kaveripattinam)	Karikala Chola is the ruler asked - victor of the battle of Venni , and credited with building the Kallanai or Grand Anicut across the Kaveri, an irrigation dam still in use
Pandya	Capital Madurai ; port Korkai	Korkai was the pearl-fishery centre . The Third Sangam was held at Madurai under Pandya patronage

The three Sangam kingdoms

Sangam literature, which is where most of this period's questions actually come from:

- 1 **Tolkappiyam** by **Tolkappiyar** - the earliest **Tamil grammar**, and the oldest surviving Tamil work
- 2 **Ettuthogai** - the **Eight Anthologies**; **Pattuppattu** - the **Ten Idylls**
- 3 **Pathinenkilkanakku** - the eighteen minor works, which include the **TIRUKKURAL** by **Thiruvalluvar**, a work of ethics in couplets and **the most examinable Tamil text of all**
- 4 The twin epics: **Silappadikaram** by **Ilango Adigal** and **Manimekalai** by **Sattanar**

KNOW · INDO-ROMAN TRADE - THE ECONOMICS OF A POLITICALLY DIVIDED INDIA

The evidence is the **Periplus of the Erythraean Sea** (F5.1), **Ptolemy's Geography**, Pliny, and **archaeology** - above all the Roman pottery, amphorae and coin hoards at **Arikamedu** near Pondicherry, which was a genuine trading settlement with a **Yavana** (Greek or west-Asian) presence.

- 1 **Ports: Barygaza (Bharuch)** and **Sopara** on the west coast, **Muziris** and **Korkai** in the far south, **Arikamedu** on the east, **Tamralipti** in Bengal
- 2 **India exported** pepper and spices, fine cotton textiles, pearls, precious stones, ivory and indigo
- 3 **India imported** wine, olive oil, glass, and above all **gold and silver coin**
- 4 **Pliny complained that the trade drained Roman gold to India** - the most quoted single line about this commerce, and the evidence of a large Indian trade surplus

The analytical point to carry out of Session 3. This is India's most politically fragmented ancient period **and one of its most prosperous** - trade, urbanisation, coinage, guilds and religious donation all flourish while a dozen dynasties compete. **So the assumption that political unity is the precondition of prosperity is not supported here: what the trade needed was stable regional authorities and open routes, not a single empire.**

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 3

- 1 Name the three theatres and say why the period must be learned as a map rather than a list
- 2 Who founded the Sungas, whom did he kill, and in what year?
- 3 Name three Sunga-period cultural items, and the pillar at Besnagar
- 4 Give the Satavahana founder, capital, greatest ruler, and the inscription issued by his mother
- 5 What are matronymics, and why do Satavahana land grants matter for later history?
- 6 Name the four waves in the north-west in order
- 7 Which ruler issued the Junagadh inscription, what is notable about its language, and what did he repair?
- 8 When does the Saka era begin and where is it used today?
- 9 Give Kanishka's capital, his council, three men he patronised, and two coinage firsts
- 10 Separate Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati by material and influence
- 11 Give all three Sangam kingdoms with capitals and ports
- 12 Name Tolkappiyam, Tirukkural and the two epics with their authors
- 13 Name four Indo-Roman ports, three exports, and what Pliny complained about

4. Session 4 - The Guptas and Harsha ★★★★★

A smaller empire than the Mauryan, held together differently, and remembered as the classical age. The second half of that sentence needs testing.

MUST MASTER · THE GUPTA DYNASTY - FIVE RULERS WHO MATTER

Founder of the line **Sri Gupta**, followed by **Ghatotkacha**, both minor. The dynasty becomes an empire with the third.

CHANDRAGUPTA I (c. 319-335 CE)

- 1 Took the title **Maharajadhiraja**, "king of great kings"
- 2 **The GUPTA ERA begins in 319-320 CE**, conventionally from his accession
- 3 Married **Kumaradevi**, a **Lichchhavi** princess - the same Vaishali clan from F5.2, and the alliance is commemorated on his coins

SAMUDRAGUPTA (c. 335-375 CE) - the great conqueror.

- 1 **The ALLAHABAD PRASHASTI (Prayag Prashasti), composed by his court poet HARISENA, is the key source** - and note the detail that it is **engraved on an Ashokan pillar**, so two dynasties speak from one stone
- 2 Called "**the Napoleon of India**" by **V. A. Smith** - a nineteenth-century historian's phrase, and **the paper asks who coined it**
- 3 **His policy differed by region, and this is the examinable part:** in **Aryavarta**, the north, he **uprooted nine kings** and annexed; in **Dakshinapatha**, the south, he **defeated twelve kings and reinstated them** as tributaries. Frontier states and foreign powers paid tribute
- 4 Performed the **ashvamedha** - the F5.2 sacrifice, revived as an imperial claim
- 5 **His coins show him playing the VINA**, which is the single most-asked Gupta coin type

CHANDRAGUPTA II VIKRAMADITYA (c. 375-415 CE) - the height of the dynasty.

- 1 **Destroyed the Shaka Western Kshatrapas** of Gujarat and Malwa, taking the title **Shakari**, and made **Ujjain** a second capital. **This completes what Session 3 left open - the Shakas end here**
- 2 **FA-HIEN visited during his reign** - the F5.1 pilgrim-patron pairing, now placed
- 3 **Introduced SILVER coinage**, taken over from the defeated Shakas, alongside the Gupta gold
- 4 The **Navaratna** or nine gems are traditionally placed at his court, including **Kalidasa**, **Amarasimha**, **Dhanvantari** and **Varahamihira**. **The tradition is late and should be stated as tradition**
- 5 Married his daughter **Prabhavatigupta** to the Vakataka ruler **Rudrasena II**, securing the Deccan by marriage rather than war
- 6 **The MEHRAULI IRON PILLAR in Delhi is attributed to a king "Chandra"**, generally identified with him - and it is the standard example of Gupta **metallurgy**, having resisted rust for sixteen centuries

KUMARAGUPTA I (c. 415-455 CE) - title **Mahendraditya**. **Founded the NALANDA Mahavihara**, the monastery-university of F5.3 - which is why its destruction around 1200 CE mattered so much.

SKANDAGUPTA (c. 455-467 CE) - **repelled the HUNAS**, and **repaired the Sudarshana lake**, recorded in a **Junagadh** inscription. **Note that this is the same lake Rudradaman I repaired three centuries earlier and the Mauryas first built** - three dynasties on one reservoir, which is a memorable and genuinely examinable chain.

MUST MASTER · GUPTA ADMINISTRATION - THE OPPOSITE OF THE MAURYAN DESIGN

This is the comparison the paper wants, and it is the most important idea in the session. The Mauryan state was centralised, salaried and inspected. **The Gupta state was decentralised, grant-based and delegated.**

The administrative hierarchy:

- 1 **Bhukti** - the province, under an **Uparika**
- 2 **Vishaya** - the district, under a **Vishayapati**
- 3 **Vithi** - a subdivision below the district
- 4 **Grama** - the village, with the headman and elders handling local affairs
- 5 **Kumaramatyā** - a senior official cadre, often princes of the blood; **Sandhivigrahika** was the minister of war and peace

The four features that make it different from the Mauryan state:

- 1 **Land grants instead of salaries.** Officials, brahmanas and temples were given **land, often with revenue and administrative rights attached** - the **agrahara** grant. **The Satavahanas began this practice; the Guptas made it normal**
- 2 **Hereditary offices.** Posts tended to become hereditary, and one man often held several - the reverse of the Mauryan inspected officialdom
- 3 **Feudatories retained.** Defeated rulers were frequently **left in place as tributaries** rather than replaced by governors - exactly what Samudragupta did in the Dakshinapatha
- 4 **Lighter central machinery.** Fewer officials, less direct economic activity by the state, and greater reliance on **guilds** and village bodies for regulation

Taxes: **bhaga** (land revenue), **bhoga** (periodic supplies to the king), and **vishti** - **forced labour**, whose appearance is a genuine sign of the era's harder side.

Why the design mattered. A grant-based state is **cheap to run and survives a weak centre better than a salaried one**, so the Guptas did not collapse as the Mauryas did. **But every grant permanently alienated revenue and authority**, so the centre weakened steadily and dissolved into regional powers. **Two empires, two failure modes: the Mauryan state broke suddenly, the Gupta state faded.**

Decline: repeated **HUNA** invasions under **Toramana** and **Mihirakula**, the loss of western trade revenue, and above all **feudatories becoming independent** as grants accumulated.

4.1 The classical achievement, and an honest verdict

Field	Name	What to know
Drama and poetry	Kalidasa	The central figure. Abhijnanashakuntalam (his masterpiece), Meghaduta , Raghuvamsha , Kumarasambhava , Malavikagnimitra , Vikramorvashiya
Drama	Sudraka; Vishakhadatta	Mrichchhakatika ("the little clay cart") by Sudraka; Mudrarakshasa by Vishakhadatta, on Chandragupta Maurya's rise - the F5.1 text, now dated
Lexicon and fable	Amarasimha; Vishnu Sharma	Amarakosha , the Sanskrit thesaurus; the Panchatantra , the animal-fable collection that travelled further west than any other Indian book
Mathematics and astronomy	ARYABHATA	Aryabhatiya . Used a place-value system , stated that the earth rotates on its axis , and gave the correct scientific explanation of eclipses as shadows rather than portents. The most examinable scientist of the period
Astronomy	Varahamihira	Brihatsamhita and Panchasiddhantika - astronomy, astrology and much incidental social detail
Medicine	Dhanvantari	Associated with Ayurveda at Chandragupta II's court. Note that Charaka belongs to the Kushana period and Susruta earlier - do not put them in the Gupta age
Architecture	-	The NAGARA temple style begins. Dashavatara temple at Deogarh; Bhitargaon, a brick temple; Udayagiri caves in Madhya Pradesh
Sculpture and painting	-	The Sarnath Buddha as the classic Gupta image; AJANTA paintings, executed under Gupta-Vakataka patronage; the Mehrauli iron pillar for metallurgy
Coinage	-	The Guptas issued the largest number of GOLD coins of any ancient Indian dynasty , called dinara - the F5.1 numismatics fact. Their purity DECLINED in the later reigns , which is itself evidence of the economic decline

Gupta-age literature, science and art - the pairings asked

BEGINNER MISTAKE · THE GOLDEN AGE CLAIM - WHAT IS TRUE, AND WHAT THE PHRASE CONCEALS

The Gupta period is routinely called India's Golden Age. **The claim is defensible for elite culture and indefensible as a description of society, and a good candidate can say both.**

What genuinely supports it:

- 1 **Sanskrit literature and drama reach their classical form** - Kalidasa is not merely good for his period
- 2 **Real scientific advance** - Aryabhata's rotating earth and eclipse explanation are correct conclusions reached by argument
- 3 **The Nagara temple style and the classic Buddha image** are formed here, and they govern Indian art for a millennium afterwards
- 4 **Prosperity and a stable gold coinage** across the core, with Fa-Hien reporting a peaceful, lightly policed society

What the phrase conceals, and this is the part candidates miss:

- 1 **Caste rigidity increased**, and the **position of untouchables worsened** - Fa-Hien himself records that **chandals had to signal their approach on entering a town**
- 2 **Women's position declined**. Property rights narrowed, marriage age fell, and **the earliest clearly dated evidence of sati in India is an inscription from Eran, of 510 CE** - which is inside this "golden" age
- 3 **Forced labour (vishti)** was a normal fiscal instrument
- 4 **The benefits were narrow**. The literature was in **Sanskrit**, which the mass of the population did not read, and the beneficiaries of land grants were a small elite

The formulation to use: a golden age for Sanskrit letters, science and art, and simultaneously a period in which social hierarchy hardened - so the phrase describes a class, not a country. That is honest, defensible, and precisely the kind of qualified answer an interview rewards over an enthusiastic one.

KNOW · HARSHAVARDHANA - THE LAST OF THE PRE-MEDIEVAL NORTH INDIAN EMPIRES

HARSHAVARDHANA (606-647 CE), of the **Pushyabhuti or Vardhana** dynasty. Capital moved from **Thanesar to KANAUJ**, which becomes the prize of north Indian politics for centuries afterwards.

- 1 Came to the throne after his brother **Rajyavardhana** was killed by **Shashanka of Gauda** (Bengal)
- 2 **Banabhatta**, his court poet, wrote the **Harshacharita** - a biography - and the romance **Kadambari**
- 3 **HIUEN TSANG visited during his reign** - the F5.1 pairing, now placed, and his account is the fullest description of seventh-century India, including **Nalanda**
- 4 **Defeated by PULAKESHIN II of the Chalukyas** of Badami, which checked his expansion into the Deccan. **The defeat is recorded in the AIHOLE inscription, composed by Ravikirti** - and note that it is recorded by the winner, not by Harsha
- 5 **He himself wrote three Sanskrit plays: Ratnavali, Nagananda and Priyadarshika** - a ruler who was also a dramatist, which is a reliable question
- 6 Held great religious assemblies at **Kanauj** and **Prayag**, and patronised Nalanda

Why he closes this chapter. Harsha is **the last ruler to hold a large north Indian empire before the medieval period**, and his empire, like the late Gupta state, rested on **feudatories rather than a bureaucracy**. **After him, north India is regional until the Delhi Sultanate** - which is where F5.7 begins.

ACTION · WHERE THIS LEAVES YOU, AND WHAT F5.5 DOES

The **rulers** slot of the F5.1 template is now full for ancient India: Magadha's four dynasties from F5.2, then Maurya, Sunga, Satavahana, the four north-western waves, the Sangam three, Gupta and Harsha. **Any chronological-order question about ancient India is now answerable, and that was this chapter's main job.**

F5.5 is the module's other highest-yield chapter: ART AND ARCHITECTURE. It has been deliberately prepared for across three chapters, and you should notice how much of it you already hold - **stupa, chaitya and vihara from F5.3; Bharhut and Sanchi placed under the Sungas; Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati separated by material; the Nagara style, Deogarh, Bhitargaon and Ajanta from this session; and the Sarnath capital in full.** F5.5 adds the temple styles in detail, the cave complexes, the Chola and later dynastic architecture, and painting - and it takes the recognition-not-recall principle to its limit, because **art questions are pure recognition and are the cheapest marks in the module.**

5. Graded Practice - 42 Questions ★★★★★

5.1 Level 1 - Recognition

Q. 1. The founder of the Mauryan empire was

- (a) Chandragupta Maurya (b) Bindusara (c) Ashoka (d) Mahapadma Nanda

Q. 2. The Arthashastra was written by

- (a) Megasthenes (b) Banabhatta (c) Harisena (d) Kautilya

Q. 3. Megasthenes came to Chandragupta's court as the ambassador of

- (a) Seleucus Nicator (b) Alexander (c) Antiochus I (d) Darius I

Q. 4. The Kalinga war was fought in about

- (a) 305 BCE (b) 273 BCE (c) 261 BCE (d) 185 BCE

Q. 5. Ashoka's remorse over the Kalinga war is recorded in

- (a) Major Rock Edict XII (b) Major Rock Edict XIII (c) the Rummindei pillar (d) the Junagadh inscription

Q. 6. Ashoka is referred to in his own inscriptions by the titles

- (a) Maharajadhiraja and Shakari (b) Amitraghata and Ugrasena (c) Devanampiya and Piyadasi (d) Mahendraditya and Vikramaditya

Q. 7. The Sarnath Lion Capital was adopted as the State Emblem of India on

- (a) 15 August 1947 (b) 26 November 1949 (c) 26 January 1952 (d) 26 January 1950

Q. 8. The sandstone used for the Ashokan pillars was quarried at

- (a) Chunar (b) Sikri (c) Makrana (d) Deogarh

Q. 9. The last Mauryan ruler, Brihadratha, was killed by

- (a) Vasudeva (b) Pushyamitra Sunga (c) Simuka (d) Nahapana

Q. 10. The capital of the Satavahanas was

- (a) Uraiyur (b) Purushapura (c) Pratishthana (d) Vidisha

Q. 11. The Junagadh or Girnar rock inscription was issued by

- (a) Kharavela (b) Skandagupta (c) Gautamiputra Satakarni (d) Rudradaman I

Q. 12. The capital of Kanishka was

(a) Purushapura (b) Taxila (c) Mathura (d) Ujjain

Q. 13. The Allahabad Prashasti was composed by

(a) Banabhatta (b) Harisena (c) Ravikirti (d) Kalidasa

Q. 14. Fa-Hien visited India during the reign of

(a) Chandragupta I (b) Samudragupta (c) Chandragupta II (d) Skandagupta

Q. 15. The Nalanda Mahavihara was founded by

(a) Chandragupta II (b) Kanishka (c) Harshavardhana (d) Kumaragupta I

Q. 16. The author of the Aryabhatiya was

(a) Aryabhata (b) Varahamihira (c) Brahmagupta (d) Dhanvantari

5.2 Level 2 - Understanding

Q. 17. By the treaty following his defeat of Seleucus Nicator, Chandragupta Maurya

(a) paid tribute in gold (b) gained Arachosia, Gedrosia and the Paropamisadae, and gave 500 war elephants (c) surrendered the Punjab (d) accepted Greek garrisons at Pataliputra

Q. 18. The four provincial capitals of the Mauryan empire were

(a) Ujjain, Paithan, Madurai and Vanji (b) Taxila, Mathura, Kanauj and Vidisha (c) Taxila, Ujjain, Suvarnagiri and Tosali (d) Peshawar, Ujjain, Amaravati and Puhar

Q. 19. In Mauryan administration, sita referred to

(a) a land tax of one-sixth (b) a category of spy (c) a toll on goods (d) crown land cultivated directly by the state

Q. 20. Which one of the following best describes Ashoka's dhamma?

(a) a common ethical and civic code addressed to a religiously plural empire (b) the imposition of Buddhist doctrine as the state religion (c) a revival of Vedic sacrifice (d) a body of criminal law

Q. 21. Ashoka's edict on religious tolerance, which argues that disparaging another sect damages one's own, is

(a) Major Rock Edict XIII (b) Major Rock Edict XII (c) the Schism edict (d) the Queen's edict

Q. 22. The Rummindei pillar inscription records

(a) the Kalinga war (b) the appointment of Dhamma Mahamatras (c) Ashoka's visit to Lumbini and a tax concession remitting bali and reducing bhaga to one-eighth (d) the repair of the Sudarshana lake

Q. 23. In the State Emblem of India, the number of lions visible is

(a) one (b) two (c) four (d) three

Q. 24. The explanation of Mauryan decline emphasising over-centralisation and weak successors is associated with

(a) Romila Thapar (b) D. D. Kosambi (c) Haraprasad Sastri (d) V. A. Smith

Q. 25. The use of matronymic names, rulers being named after their mothers, is a distinctive feature of the

(a) Sungas (b) Satavahanas (c) Kushanas (d) Guptas

Q. 26. The first coins in India to carry a portrait and the name of the issuing king were issued by the

(a) Mauryas (b) Kushanas (c) Indo-Greeks (d) Guptas

Q. 27. The Gandhara and Mathura schools are distinguished by material in that

(a) both used grey schist (b) both used white marble (c) Gandhara used spotted red sandstone and Mathura white limestone (d) Gandhara used grey schist and Mathura spotted red sandstone

Q. 28. The Saka era, used in the Indian national calendar, begins in

(a) 58 BCE (b) 78 CE (c) 320 CE (d) 606 CE

Q. 29. Samudragupta was described as "the Napoleon of India" by

(a) V. A. Smith (b) Romila Thapar (c) R. S. Sharma (d) D. D. Kosambi

Q. 30. In Gupta administration, the province was called a

(a) vishaya, under a vishayapati (b) bhukti, under an uparika (c) janapada, under a rajuka (d) ahara, under a pradeshika

5.3 Level 3 - Recruitment Test standard

Q. 31. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Inscription)	List-II (Ruler)
A. Allahabad Prashasti	1. Rudradaman I
B. Junagadh rock inscription	2. Pulakeshin II
C. Hathigumpha inscription	3. Samudragupta
D. Aihole inscription	4. Kharavela

(a) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2 (b) A-1 B-3 C-4 D-2 (c) A-3 B-1 C-4 D-2 (d) A-2 B-1 C-4 D-3

Q. 32. Which one of the following statements about Ashoka's dhamma is NOT correct?

(a) It enjoined respect for elders and toleration of all sects (b) It restricted animal slaughter and royal hunts (c) It was promoted through officers called Dhamma Mahamatras (d) It set out the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path

Q. 33. Arrange the following dynasties in correct chronological order, earliest first: 1. Kushana · 2. Maurya · 3. Gupta · 4. Sunga

(a) 2-4-1-3 (b) 2-1-4-3 (c) 4-2-1-3 (d) 2-4-3-1

Q. 34. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Dynasty or kingdom)	List-II (Capital)
A. Satavahana	1. Madurai
B. Kushana	2. Pratishthana
C. Pandya	3. Vanji
D. Chera	4. Purushapura

(a) A-2 B-1 C-4 D-3 (b) A-2 B-4 C-1 D-3 (c) A-4 B-2 C-1 D-3 (d) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2

Q. 35. Consider the following statements about Mauryan administration: 1. The Samaharta was the chief collector of revenue. · 2. Sita was crown land cultivated directly by the state. · 3. Provinces were governed by viceroys titled Kumara. Which are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only (c) 1, 2 and 3 (d) 2 and 3 only

Q. 36. Which one of the following statements about the Gupta state is NOT correct?

(a) Provinces were called bhuktis and districts vishayas (b) Land grants to brahmanas and officials became widespread (c) Defeated rulers were often retained as tributary feudatories (d) It was more centralised than the Mauryan state

Q. 37. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Port or site)	List-II (Description)
A. Muziris	1. Pandya pearl-fishery centre
B. Korkai	2. Roman trading settlement with a Yavana presence
C. Puhar	3. Chera pepper port named in Roman sources
D. Arikamedu	4. Chola port on the Kaveri

(a) A-3 B-1 C-4 D-2 (b) A-1 B-3 C-4 D-2 (c) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2 (d) A-2 B-1 C-3 D-4

Q. 38. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Ruler)	List-II (Associated with)
A. Chandragupta I	1. Defeated the western Shakas; Fa-Hien's visit
B. Samudragupta	2. Founded the Gupta era; married Kumaradevi
C. Chandragupta II	3. Repelled the Hunas; repaired the Sudarshana lake
D. Skandagupta	4. Allahabad Prashasti; ashvamedha; vina coins

(a) A-2 B-1 C-4 D-3 (b) A-2 B-4 C-1 D-3 (c) A-4 B-2 C-1 D-3 (d) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2

Q. 39. Which one of the following statements about the sculpture schools is NOT correct?

(a) Gandhara used grey schist and shows strong Greco-Roman influence (b) Mathura used spotted red sandstone and continued indigenous conventions (c) Gandhara sculpture was executed in spotted red sandstone from Sikri (d) Amaravati used white limestone and favoured crowded narrative panels

Q. 40. Consider the following statements about Indo-Roman trade: 1. Arikamedu yielded Roman pottery and evidence of a Yavana presence. · 2. Pliny complained that the trade drained Roman gold to India. · 3. India's principal import was cotton textiles. Which are correct?

(a) 1 only (b) 1, 2 and 3 (c) 2 and 3 only (d) 1 and 2 only

Q. 41. Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the code below:

List-I (Text)	List-II (Author)
A. Tolkappiyam	1. Thiruvalluvar
B. Tirukkural	2. Sattanar
C. Silappadikaram	3. Tolkappiyar
D. Manimekalai	4. Ilango Adigal

(a) A-3 B-1 C-4 D-2 (b) A-1 B-3 C-4 D-2 (c) A-3 B-4 C-1 D-2 (d) A-4 B-1 C-3 D-2

Q. 42. Harshavardhana's expansion into the Deccan was checked by

(a) Shashanka of Gauda (b) Pulakeshin II of the Chalukyas (c) Toramana of the Hunas (d) Rudradaman I of the Shakas

6. Answers and Explanations

6.1 Level 1 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
1	a	Chandragupta Maurya , who overthrew (d) Mahapadma Nanda's successor Dhana Nanda with Kautilya's help. (b) Bindusara was his son and (c) Ashoka his grandson
2	d	Kautilya (Chanakya) . (a) Megasthenes wrote the Indica , (c) Harisena the Allahabad Prashasti , (b) Banabhatta the Harshacharita - all three are real pairings, which is what makes the question work
3	a	Seleucus Nicator , sent as part of the settlement following his defeat in about 305 BCE. (c) Antiochus I sent Deimachus , to Bindusara - the near-miss
4	c	c. 261 BCE , in Ashoka's eighth regnal year . (a) 305 BCE is the Seleucus settlement and (d) 185 BCE the end of the dynasty
5	b	Major Rock Edict XIII - the only ancient Indian record of a king expressing regret for his own victory. (a) XII is the edict of religious tolerance
6	c	Devanampiya ("beloved of the gods") and Piyadasi ("of pleasing appearance"). (a) Maharajadhiraja is Chandragupta I and Shakari Chandragupta II; (b) Amitraghata is Bindusara; (d) are Gupta titles
7	d	26 January 1950 , the day the Constitution came into force
8	a	Chunar , near Varanasi - and the stone was transported hundreds of miles, which is itself evidence of Mauryan organisation. (b) Sikri supplied the spotted red sandstone of the Mathura school
9	b	Pushyamitra Sunga , his own commander, in about 185 BCE . (a) Vasudeva later killed the last Sunga , Devabhuti, founding the Kanvas - the same pattern one dynasty later
10	c	Pratishthana (Paithan) . (b) Purushapura is Kanishka's, (a) Uraiyur the Chola capital, (d) Vidisha a Sunga centre
11	d	Rudradaman I , the Shaka Western Kshatrapa - and the inscription is the first long inscription in Sanskrit , recording his repair of the Sudarshana lake
12	a	Purushapura (Peshawar) , with (c) Mathura as a second centre - which is why Mathura is the distractor
13	b	Harisena , Samudragupta's court poet - and it is engraved on an Ashokan pillar , so two dynasties speak from one stone

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
14	c	Chandragupta II. (d) Skandagupta repelled the Hunas. Hiuen Tsang, by contrast, visited Harshavardhana - the F5.1 pairing
15	d	Kumaragupta I , whose title was Mahendraditya . Its sacking around 1200 CE is one of the five causes of Buddhism's decline in F5.3
16	a	Aryabhata. (b) Varahamihira wrote the Brihatsamhita and Panchasiddhantika ; (c) Brahmagupta is later, of the seventh century

6.2 Level 2 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
17	b	Territory gained and 500 elephants given. Note the direction of the transaction: an Indian ruler defeated a Macedonian successor state and gained land , which is the answer to any option implying Greek dominance persisted after Alexander. (a), (c) and (d) all invert it
18	c	Taxila (north-west), Ujjain (west), Suvarnagiri (south), Tosali (east), with Pataliputra at the centre. (a) lists Deccan and Sangam capitals , and (d) mixes periods - Peshawar is Kushana
19	d	Crown land cultivated directly by the state - evidence of a large state farming sector, which is unusual for the ancient world and is why it is asked. (a) is the land-revenue rate, a different thing
20	a	A common ethical and civic code for a plural empire. (b) is the standard wrong answer and it is offered constantly: Ashoka was personally Buddhist, but the dhamma of the edicts contains none of the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, nirvana or anatta
21	b	Major Rock Edict XII , which goes beyond tolerance to argue that disparaging another sect damages one's own. (c) The Schism edict is about preventing splits within the sangha - a different subject
22	c	The Lumbini visit and the tax concession - bali remitted, bhaga reduced to one-eighth. It is the clearest surviving instance of an Ashokan fiscal order. (d) the Sudarshana lake belongs to Rudradaman I and Skandagupta
23	d	Three. The fourth lion is hidden behind. The Emblem is an adaptation, not a copy - it also omits the bell-shaped inverted lotus of the Sarnath original, and options asserting a faithful reproduction are wrong
24	a	Romila Thapar , and it is the strongest of the four explanations. (c) Haraprasad Sastri argued Brahmanical reaction; (b) D. D. Kosambi financial strain; (d) V. A. Smith is the "Napoleon of India" phrase, a different question entirely
25	b	Satavahanas - Gautamiputra means "son of Gautami". Unusual enough in Indian dynastic practice to be a reliable identifier
26	c	Indo-Greeks - which is why their chronology is better established than that of contemporary Indian dynasties. (d) The Guptas issued the largest number of gold coins, and (b) the Kushanas the purest gold and the first Buddha images on coinage - three different numismatic firsts, and the paper tests which is which
27	d	Gandhara grey schist, Mathura spotted red sandstone from Sikri , with Amaravati in white limestone. Material alone answers most questions on the schools , which is why it is the thing to learn
28	b	78 CE , conventionally identified with Kanishka's accession , and the era of the Indian national calendar. (a) 58 BCE is the Vikrama era and (c) 320 CE the Gupta era
29	a	V. A. Smith - a nineteenth-century historian's phrase, and the paper asks who coined it rather than whether it is apt

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
30	b	Bhukti under an uparika. (a) The vishaya under a vishayapati is the DISTRICT , one level below - and offering both is exactly how this question is built

6.3 Level 3 - answers

Q	Ans	Why, and why the others fail
31	c	A-3 Allahabad Prashasti-Samudragupta · B-1 Junagadh-Rudradaman I · C-4 Hathigumpha-Kharavela · D-2 Aihole-Pulakeshin II. This is the standard inscription-to-ruler matching set and it is cheap to learn. Kharavela's Hathigumpha came from F5.3, and Aihole records Harsha's defeat
32	d	(d) is the false statement, and it is the chapter's central distinction. Ashoka's dhamma contains no distinctively Buddhist doctrine - no Four Noble Truths, no Eightfold Path, no nirvana, no anatta. (a), (c) and (b) are all accurate descriptions of it
33	a	2-4-1-3: Maurya (321-185 BCE), Sunga (from 185 BCE), Kushana (1st-3rd century CE), Gupta (from 320 CE). The Sungas follow the Mauryas immediately because Pushyamitra killed Brihadratha
34	b	A-2 Satavahana-Pratishthana · B-4 Kushana-Purushapura · C-1 Pandya-Madurai · D-3 Chera-Vanji. Fixing only Kushana-Purushapura and Pandya-Madurai eliminates (a), (c) and (d)
35	c	All three are correct. The Samaharta collected revenue and the Sannidhata kept the treasury; sita was directly cultivated crown land; provinces went to viceroys of royal blood titled Kumara or Aryaputra
36	d	(d) is false, and it inverts the session's central comparison. The Gupta state was LESS centralised than the Mauryan - land grants instead of salaries, hereditary offices, retained feudatories and lighter central machinery. (a), (b) and (c) are all true, and together they describe exactly why it was less centralised
37	a	A-3 Muziris, the Chera pepper port · B-1 Korkai, the Pandya pearl fishery · C-4 Puhar, the Chola port · D-2 Arikamedu, the Roman trading settlement near Pondicherry with Roman pottery and a Yavana presence
38	b	A-2 Chandragupta I founded the era and married the Lichchhavi Kumaradevi · B-4 Samudragupta of the Allahabad Prashasti, the ashvamedha and the vana coins · C-1 Chandragupta II beat the Shakas and hosted Fa-Hien · D-3 Skandagupta repelled the Hunas and repaired the Sudarshana lake. Note the lake links Mauryas, Rudradaman I and Skandagupta - three dynasties on one reservoir
39	c	(c) is false and simply swaps the materials. Spotted red sandstone from Sikri is MATHURA; Gandhara worked in grey schist. (a), (b) and (d) state the three schools correctly. This is the same distinction as Q27, tested in the "not correct" format - which is how the paper checks whether you hold it firmly or merely recognise it
40	d	1 and 2 only. Statement 3 inverts the trade: cotton textiles were among India's principal EXPORTS , along with pepper, spices, pearls and gems. India imported wine, olive oil, glass and above all gold and silver coin - which is precisely why Pliny complained of the drain of Roman gold
41	a	A-3 Tolkappiyam-Tolkappiyar · B-1 Tirukkural-Thiruvalluvar · C-4 Silappadikaram-Ilango Adigal · D-2 Manimekalai-Sattanar. Tirukkural is the most examinable Tamil text of all , and knowing that pair alone eliminates (b) and (d)
42	b	Pulakeshin II of the Chalukyas of Badami , recorded in the Aihole inscription composed by Ravikirti - and note it is recorded by the winner. (a) Shashanka of Gauda killed Harsha's brother Rajyavardhana , which is the other Harsha fact and the intended confusion

7. One-Minute Revision

ONE-MINUTE REVISION · CHAPTER F5.4 - MAURYAS, POST-MAURYAN KINGDOMS, GUPTAS

WHAT THIS CHAPTER IS FOR it fills the **RULERS** slot of the F5.1 template for all of ancient India, so **every chronological-order question comes from here** · for most dynasties you need only **founder, greatest ruler, capital, one achievement** · the post-Mauryan centuries are a **MAP, not a sequence**

MAURYAN SOURCES - three kinds, none neutral **Ashoka's inscriptions** contemporary and official, unreadable until **Prinsep 1837** · **Arthashastra of Kautilya** prescriptive - how a state SHOULD work · **Megasthenes' Indica** foreign, second-hand, surviving only in fragments

CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA c. 321-297 BCE overthrew **Dhana Nanda** with **Kautilya** · **defeated SELEUCUS NICATOR c. 305 BCE**, gained **Arachosia, Gedrosia, Paropamisadae**, gave **500 elephants**, received **Megasthenes** · became a **Jain**, died by **sallekhana at Shravanabelagola** · capital **Pataliputra**

BINDUSARA c. 297-273 BCE title **Amitraghata** (Greek Amitrochates) · **Ajivika** leaning · ambassador **Deimachus** from **Antiochus I**

MAURYAN ADMINISTRATION council **Mantriparishad**, **Mahamatya / Amatya**, **27 adhyakshas** · **FOUR PROVINCES: TAXILA (NW), UJJAIN (W), SUVARNAGIRI (S), TOSALI (E)** + **Pataliputra** centre, viceroys **Kumara / Aryaputra** · district **Pradeshika, Rajuka, Yukta**; village **Gramika** ·

SAMAHARTA revenue, **SANNIDHATA** treasury · revenue ~1/6, **SITA = crown land farmed by the state** · city under **Nagaraka**, Megasthenes' **6 committees of 5** for the city and **6 for the war office**, army **600,000 / 30,000 / 9,000 (REPORTED)** · spies **gudhapurushas** - **sanstha** stationed, **sanchara** wandering, **watching officials as much as enemies** · unusual: **a large state economic sector** and **written, inspected central control**

ASHOKA c. 268-232 BCE titles **DEVANAMPIYA PIYADASI**; personal name only in the **MASKI and GUJARRA** minor rock edicts · **KALINGA WAR c. 261 BCE, 8th regnal year, recorded in MAJOR ROCK EDICT XIII** with remorse - **the only ancient Indian record of a king regretting his own victory** · then **DHAMMA VIJAYA**, conquest by righteousness · **THIRD Buddhist Council Pataliputra c. 250 BCE**, missionaries **Mahendra and Sanghamitra to Sri Lanka** · the irony: **Kalinga completed the empire and ended the policy that built it**

DHAMMA IS NOT BUDDHISM - the chapter's key distinction contents: **respect for elders and brahmanas** · **ahimsa and restraint on slaughter and royal hunts** · **truthfulness and kindness to servants** · **TOLERATION of all sects** · **practical welfare (roads, wells, rest houses, medicine)** · **ABSENT: Four Noble Truths, Eightfold Path, nirvana, anatta, the sangha as lay obligation** · so: **a common ethical code for a plural empire, NOT the propagation of Buddhism** · enforced by **DHAMMA MAHAMATRAS** created in the **13th regnal year**

THE EDICTS **14 Major Rock Edicts (XIII Kalinga, XII religious tolerance - disparaging another sect damages your own)** · **Minor Rock Edicts (Maski, Gujarra name Ashoka)** · **7 Major Pillar Edicts** · **Minor Pillar Edicts - RUMMINDEI: Lumbini visit + TAX CONCESSION, bali remitted and bhaga cut to 1/8; Schism edict; Queen's edict (Karuvaki)** · **KANDAHAR bilingual GREEK + ARAMAIC** · language **Prakrit**, script **Brahmi** with **Kharosthi** in the north-west · **the edict distribution IS the map of the empire**

THE PILLARS AND THE STATE EMBLEM stone quarried at **CHUNAR**, **monolithic**, highly polished · capitals: **lion at SARNATH**, **bull at RAMPURVA**, **elephant at SANKISA** · **Sarnath Lion Capital** adopted as **STATE EMBLEM on 26 JANUARY 1950** · only **THREE lions visible, the inverted lotus is OMITTED**, motto "**Satyameva Jayate**" from the **MUNDAKA UPANISHAD**, and the **abacus wheel is the flag's Dharmachakra** - the Emblem is an **ADAPTATION, not a copy**

MAURYAN DECLINE last king **Brihadratha** killed by **PUSHYAMITRA SUNGA c. 185 BCE** · **Haraprasad Sastri** Brahmanical reaction (weak - the edicts respect brahmanas) · **D. D. Kosambi** financial strain from debased coinage · popular pacifism argument (weak - the empire lasted 50 more years) · **ROMILA THAPAR** over-centralisation and weak successors - the strongest · the features that made the state impressive are the ones that made it unable to survive a weak centre

SUNGA and **KANVA** Pushyamitra Sunga 185 BCE, Pataliputra and **Vidisha**, revived **ashvamedha** · **Patanjali's Mahabhashya** · **BHARHUT** stupa and the **SANCHI** railings and gateways are Sunga work · **Heliodorus pillar** at **BESNAGAR** - a Greek envoy turned Vaishnava · **Kalidasa's Malavikagnimitra** is about **Agnimitra** · last ruler **Devabhuti**, killed by **Vasudeva** who founds the **KANVAS**

SATAVAHANAS founder **Simuka**, capital **PRATISHTHANA (PAITHAN)** · **GAUTAMIPUTRA SATAKARNI** the greatest - beat **Nahapana**, called **destroyer of Shakas, Pahlavas and Yavanas** in the **NASIK PRASHASTI** issued by his mother **GAUTAMI BALASHRI** · **MATRONYMIC** names · language **Prakrit**, coins **lead and potin** · **FIRST** systematic **LAND GRANTS** to **brahmanas and Buddhist monks** - the seed of the **agrahara** system and of the whole **Gupta design** · patronised **Karle, Nasik, Amaravati**

THE FOUR NORTH-WESTERN WAVES, IN ORDER INDO-GREEKS - MENANDER (Milinda), converted by **Nagasena, Milindapanha**; **FIRST** portrait-and-name coins in India; seed the **Gandhara school** · **SHAKAS** - **Nahapana**, **RUDRADAMAN I** of the **JUNAGADH / GIRNAR** inscription, the **FIRST LONG SANSKRIT** inscription, repaired the **Sudarshana lake**; **SAKA ERA 78 CE = the Indian national calendar** · **PARTHIANS / PAHLAVAS** - **Gondophernes**, the **St Thomas** tradition · **KUSHANAS** - **KANISHKA** acc. 78 CE, capital **PURUSHAPURA (PESHAWAR)** with **Mathura** second, **FOURTH Buddhist Council** in **Kashmir**, patronised **Ashvaghosha, Vasumitra, Nagarjuna, Charaka, PUREST GOLD COINS** of ancient India and the **FIRST BUDDHA IMAGES** on coinage

THE THREE SCULPTURE SCHOOLS - material answers the question **GANDHARA = GREY SCHIST**, Greco-Roman, wavy hair, heavy folds, moustache; "Greco-Buddhist" · **MATHURA = SPOTTED RED SANDSTONE** from **SIKRI**, indigenous, shaven head, decorated halo; Jain and Brahmanical images too · **AMARAVATI = WHITE LIMESTONE**, Satavahana/Ikshvaku, crowded narrative panels

THE SANGAM SOUTH CHERA Vanji (Karur), port **MUZIRIS** the pepper port · **CHOLA** Uraiyur, port **Puhar**, **KARIKALA** won at **Venni** and built the **GRAND ANICUT (Kallanai)** · **PANDYA MADURAI**, port **Korkai** the pearl fishery, **Third Sangam** at **Madurai** · **TOLKAPPIYAM** by **Tolkappiyar**, earliest Tamil grammar · **Ettuthogai** eight anthologies, **Pattuppattu** ten idylls · **TIRUKKURAL** by **THIRUVALLUVAR** · **SILAPPADIKARAM** by **Ilango Adigal**, **MANIMEKALAI** by **Sattanar**

INDO-ROMAN TRADE evidence **Periplus**, **Ptolemy**, **Pliny** and **ARIKAMEDU** with Roman pottery and **Yavanas** · ports **Barygaza, Sopara, Muziris, Korkai, Arikamedu, Tamralipti** · **EXPORTS** pepper, cotton textiles, pearls, gems, ivory · **IMPORTS** wine, olive oil, glass and above all **GOLD AND SILVER COIN** · **PLINY** complained the trade **DRAINED ROMAN GOLD** · so India's most fragmented ancient period is also one of its most prosperous - political unity is NOT the precondition of prosperity

GUPTA DYNASTY Sri Gupta then **Ghatotkacha**, minor · **CHANDRAGUPTA I** - **Maharajadhiraja**, **GUPTA ERA 319-320 CE**, married the Lichchhavi **Kumaradevi** · **SAMUDRAGUPTA** - **ALLAHABAD PRASHASTI** by **HARISENA**, engraved on an **ASHOKAN PILLAR**, "Napoleon of India" by **V. A. SMITH**, **Aryavarta 9 kings UPROOTED / Dakshinapatha 12 kings DEFEATED AND REINSTATED**, **ashvamedha**, **VINA** coins · **CHANDRAGUPTA II VIKRAMADITYA** - destroyed the western **Shakas**, title **Shakari**, **Ujjain** second capital, **FA-HIEN** visited, introduced **SILVER** coinage, the **Navaratna** (tradition), daughter **Prabhavatigupta** married the Vakataka **Rudrasena II**, **MEHRAULI IRON PILLAR** attributed to "Chandra" · **KUMARAGUPTA I (Mahendraditya)** - **FOUNDED NALANDA** · **SKANDAGUPTA** - repelled the **HUNAS**, repaired the **Sudarshana lake** (**Junagadh** again - **Mauryas** built it, **Rudradaman I** and **Skandagupta** repaired it)

GUPTA ADMINISTRATION - the **OPPOSITE** of Mauryan **BHUKTI** province under an **Uparika** · **VISHAYA** district under a **Vishayapati** · **Vithi** then **Grama** · **Kumaramaty** senior cadre, **Sandhivigraha** war and peace · four differences: **LAND GRANTS (agrahara)** instead of **SALARIES** · **HEREDITARY** and plural office-holding · **FEUDATORIES RETAINED** as tributaries · lighter central machinery, more reliance on guilds and villages · taxes **bhaga**, **bhoga**, and **VISHTI** = **FORCED LABOUR** · a grant-based state is cheap and survives weak kings, but every grant permanently alienates revenue - so the Mauryan state **BROKE** suddenly and the Gupta state **FADED** · decline: **HUNAS** under **TORAMANA** and **MIHIRAKULA**, lost western trade, and **feudatories becoming independent**

GUPTA CULTURE **KALIDASA** - **Abhijnanashakuntalam**, **Meghaduta**, **Raghuvamsha**, **Kumarasambhava**, **Malavikagnimitra**, **Vikramorvashiya** · **Mrichchhakatika-SUDRAKA** · **Mudrarakshasa-VISHAKHADATTA** · **Amarakosha-AMARASIMHA** · **Panchatantra-VISHNU SHARMA** · **ARYABHATA's Aryabhata** - place value, **THE EARTH ROTATES ON ITS AXIS**, eclipses as **SHADOWS** not portents · **VARAHAMIHIRA** - **Brihatsamhita**, **Panchasiddhantika** · **Dhanvantari** medicine, but **CHARAKA** is **KUSHANA** and **SUSRUTA** earlier - do **NOT** date them Gupta · **NAGARA** style **BEGINS**: **DEOGARH**, **BHITARGAON** brick temple, **Udayagiri caves** · **Sarnath Buddha**, **AJANTA** paintings, **Mehrauli iron pillar** · **MOST GOLD COINS (dinara)**, purity **DECLINING** later - itself evidence of decline

THE GOLDEN AGE, HONESTLY FOR: classical Sanskrit letters, real science, the Nagara style and the classic Buddha image, prosperity and stable gold · **AGAINST**: **caste rigidity increased and untouchables' position worsened** (Fa-Hien records **chandalas signalling their approach**), **women's position declined**, the earliest clearly dated **SATI** evidence is the **ERAN inscription of 510 CE** - inside the golden age, **vishti** was normal, and the benefits were narrow and Sanskrit-bound · so: a golden age for letters, science and art **AND** a **hardening of social hierarchy** - the phrase describes a **CLASS**, not a country

HARSHAVARDHANA 606-647 CE **Pushyabhuti / Vardhana**, **Thanesar** → **KANAUJ** · succeeded after **Rajyavardhana** was killed by **SHASHANKA OF GAUDA** · **BANABHATTA** wrote **Harshacharita** and **Kadambari** · **HIUEN TSANG** visited · **BEATEN BY PULAKESHIN II**, recorded in the **AIHOLE inscription** by **RAVIKIRTI** - by the winner · wrote **Ratnavali**, **Nagananda**, **Priyadarshika** · assemblies at **Kanauj** and **Prayag** · the last large north Indian empire before the medieval period, and it too rested on feudatories not a bureaucracy

8. Five-Minute Wall Sheet

FIVE-MINUTE WALL SHEET · CHAPTER F5.4 - MAURYAS TO GUPTAS

This chapter = the RULERS slot · all chronological-order questions come from here

Sources: EDICTS (contemporary) · ARTHASHASTRA (prescriptive) · MEGASTHENES (foreign, fragmentary)

CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA: beat SELEUCUS c. 305 BCE, gained land, gave 500 ELEPHANTS, got MEGASTHENES

Died a JAIN by SALLEKHANA at SHRAVANABELAGOLA · BINDUSARA = AMITRAGHATA, Ajivika

PROVINCES: TAXILA NW · UJJAIN W · SUVARNAGIRI S · TOSALI E · viceroy = KUMARA SAMAHARTA revenue · SANNIDHATA treasury · SITA = state-farmed crown land · NAGARAKA city

Spies GUDHAPURUSHAS: SANSTHA stationed, SANCHARA wandering - they watched OFFICIALS

ASHOKA = DEVANAMPIYA PIYADASI · name only in MASKI + GUJARRA

KALINGA c. 261 BCE, 8th regnal year, MAJOR ROCK EDICT XIII · then DHAMMA VIJAYA EDICT XII = RELIGIOUS TOLERANCE · RUMMINDEI = Lumbini + tax cut (bhaga to 1/8)

KANDAHAR = GREEK + ARAMAIC · 14 major rock · 7 major pillar · DHAMMA MAHAMATRAS in year 13

DHAMMA IS NOT BUDDHISM - no Four Truths, no Eightfold Path, no nirvana, no anatta

Pillars: CHUNAR stone, monolithic · LION Sarnath · BULL Rampurva · ELEPHANT Sankisa

STATE EMBLEM 26 JAN 1950 · THREE lions visible · LOTUS OMITTED · an ADAPTATION not a copy

Decline: THAPAR over-centralisation (strongest) · KOSAMBI finance · SASTRI Brahmanical reaction

Brihadratha killed by PUSHYAMITRA SUNGA 185 BCE · Devabhuti killed by VASUDEVA (Kanva)

SUNGA: BHARHUT + SANCHI railings · PATANJALI · HELIODORUS pillar at BESNAGAR

SATAVAHANA: Simuka · PRATISHTHANA/PAITHAN · GAUTAMIPUTRA SATAKARNI beat NAHAPANA

NASIK PRASHASTI by his mother GAUTAMI BALASHRI · MATRonymics · FIRST LAND GRANTS

Waves: INDO-GREEKS → SHAKAS → PARTHIANS → KUSHANAS

MENANDER + NAGASENA = Milindapanha · Indo-Greeks = FIRST PORTRAIT COINS

RUDRADAMAN I = JUNAGADH, FIRST LONG SANSKRIT inscription, SUDARSHANA LAKE

SAKA ERA 78 CE = national calendar · GONDOPHERNES = St Thomas tradition

KANISHKA: PURUSHAPURA · 4th COUNCIL Kashmir · PUREST GOLD · FIRST BUDDHA ON COINS

GANDHARA = GREY SCHIST + Greek · MATHURA = RED SPOTTED SANDSTONE + indigenous · AMARAVATI = WHITE LIMESTONE

CHERA-Vanji-MUZIRIS · CHOLA-Uraiyur-Puhar-KARIKALA-GRAND ANICUT ·

PANDYA-MADURAI-Korkai pearls

TOLKAPPIYAM-Tolkappiyar · TIRUKKURAL-THIRUVALLUVAR · SILAPPADIKARAM-Ilango · MANIMEKALAI-Sattanar

ARIKAMEDU = Roman pottery + Yavanas · PLINY: the trade DRAINED ROMAN GOLD

Fragmented politics + high prosperity = unity is NOT the precondition of wealth

GUPTA ERA 319-320 CE (Chandragupta I, married Lichchhavi KUMARADEVI)

SAMUDRAGUPTA: ALLAHABAD PRASHASTI by HARISENA on an ASHOKAN PILLAR ·

"Napoleon" by V. A. SMITH

Aryavarta 9 UPROOTED · Dakshinapatha 12 DEFEATED AND REINSTATED · VINA coins

CHANDRAGUPTA II: beat the SHAKAS, FA-HIEN, SILVER coins, MEHRAULI IRON PILLAR, Ujjain

KUMARAGUPTA I founded **NALANDA** · **SKANDAGUPTA** repelled the **HUNAS** + **Sudarshana** lake again
GUPTA STATE = **BHUKTI** (uparika) → **VISHAYA** (vishayapati) → vithi → grama
LAND GRANTS not salaries · **HEREDITARY** offices · **FEUDATORIES KEPT** · **VISHTI** = forced labour
LESS centralised than Mauryan · Mauryan state **BROKE**, Gupta state **FADED** · Hunas
TORAMANA + **MIHIRAKULA**
KALIDASA · **SUDRAKA**-Mrichchhakatika · **AMARAKOSHA**-Amarasimha ·
PANCHATANTRA-Vishnu Sharma
ARYABHATA: place value, **EARTH ROTATES**, **ECLIPSES = SHADOWS** · **VARAHAMIHIRA**:
Brihatsamhita
CHARAKA is **KUSHANA**, not Gupta · **NAGARA** style begins · **DEOGARH** · **BHITARGAON** brick ·
AJANTA
MOST GOLD COINS (dinara) but purity **FELL** later
GOLDEN AGE, honestly: caste hardened, women's status fell, **SATI** at **ERAN 510 CE**, vishti normal - it describes a **CLASS**, not a country
HARSHA 606-647: **THANESAR** → **KANAUJ** · **BANABHATTA** · **HIUEN TSANG** · wrote **Ratnavali**, **Nagananda**, **Priyadarshika**
Harsha BEATEN BY PULAKESHIN II - **AIHOLE** inscription by **RAVIKIRTI** · **SHASHANKA** killed his brother · last big north Indian empire before the medieval age